

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Nature of Politics and Communitarianism - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Nature of Politics and Communitarianism

TEN-SESSION CORE PATH • PRACTICE • OPTIONAL ADVANCED • REGISTER NOTES

1 Politics as Public Conflict and Authoritative Resolution

2 Definitions, Chapter Spine and Essential Distinctions

3 Thinkers, Positions and the Three Rival Social Images

4 Illustrations and the Liberty-Equality-Fraternity Matrix

5 Trap Repair, Boundaries, Revision and Source Discipline

6 MacIntyre: Traditions, Practices and Internal Goods

7 Taylor: Dialogical Identity and Recognition

8 Sandel, the Unencumbered Self and Cautious Precursors

9 Communitarian Objections, Liberal Replies and Indian Application

10 Directive Decoding and Mark-Scaled Answer Architecture

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Nature of Politics and Communitarianism - Solved Practice Workbook

Generation: learner-v2:g2 **PYQ ownership:** No directly owned verified PYQ is assigned to this topic; all questions below are original practice.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Politics**?

A. A public process involving conflict, its resolution, and authoritative value-allocation in society. B. A view stressing that persons are socially constituted, owe duties to the community, and should seek their good through the good of the community. C. Contemporary communitarians criticize the atomistic individual and stress embedded identity, virtue, shared understanding and common good. D. the self is unintelligible outside the narrative of a particular community and moral tradition; virtues are acquired only through participation in social "practices" (activities with internal standards of excellence - e.g. medicine, craft, scholarship) sustained by inherited traditions.

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Politics** with **A public process involving conflict, its resolution, and authoritative value-allocation in society**.. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 2

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **A public process involving conflict, its resolution, and authoritative value-allocation in society**.

A. Alasdair MacIntyre - mechanism B. Politics C. Michael Sandel - critique of the unencumbered self D. Authoritative allocation of values

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **A public process involving conflict, its resolution, and authoritative value-allocation in society**. with **Politics**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 3

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Political situation**?

A. Politics begins with the polis, and communitarian strands later revive his idea that political association is tied to good life. B. A plurality of individuals and groups with reconcilable interests. C. A situation of public conflict among major groups that calls for a universal/public solution, not a private settlement. D. a practice has "internal goods" (excellence achieved through the activity itself) understandable and judgeable only from within its own tradition of standards.

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Political situation** with **A situation of public conflict among major groups that calls for a universal/public solution, not a private settlement**.. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 4

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **A situation of public conflict among major groups that calls for a universal/public solution, not a private settlement**.

A. Alasdair MacIntyre - significance B. Michael Sandel - mechanism C. Liberal view of politics D. Political situation

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **A situation of public conflict among major groups that calls for a universal/public solution, not a private settlement.** with **Political situation.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 5

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Authoritative allocation of values**?

A. Easton's idea that politics distributes valued things through decisions treated as binding because they carry authority, not mere brute force. B. Politics is the authoritative allocation of values for society. C. Reconciliation and authoritative settlement of disputes. D. morality cannot be reconstructed from an abstract, tradition-free standpoint, as much liberal theory attempts; moral reasoning is always reasoning within an inherited tradition.

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Authoritative allocation of values** with **Easton's idea that politics distributes valued things through decisions treated as binding because they carry authority, not mere brute force.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 6

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **Easton's idea that politics distributes valued things through decisions treated as binding because they carry authority, not mere brute force.**

A. Charles Taylor - dialogical self and recognition B. Authoritative allocation of values C. Michael Sandel - significance D. Marxist view of politics

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Easton's idea that politics distributes valued things through decisions treated as binding because they carry authority, not mere brute force.** with **Authoritative allocation of values.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 7

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Liberal view of politics**?

A. Locke-linked liberalism treats society as composed of multiple organized groups seeking accommodation through the state. B. A balanced outcome accommodating contending interests. C. Politics as group-and-state activity aimed at reconciling competing interests and promoting a common good compatible with them. D. the self is "dialogical," not monological - identity is formed through language and relationships with "significant others," and a person's self-understanding depends partly on being adequately recognised by others.

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Liberal view of politics** with **Politics as group-and-state activity aimed at reconciling competing interests and promoting a common good compatible with them.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 8

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **Politics as group-and-state activity aimed at reconciling competing interests and promoting a common good compatible with them.**

A. Charles Taylor - mechanism B. Politics C. Communitarianism D. Liberal view of politics

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Politics as group-and-state activity aimed at reconciling competing interests and promoting a common good compatible with them.** with **Liberal view of politics.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 9

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Marxist view of politics**?

A. Politics as an effect of class division, used by the dominant class to hold down the dependent class until class society is abolished. B. Politics and the state arise from class division and serve dominant-class interests until class conflict ends in a classless order. C. Order, justice and welfare within society. D. withholding or distorting recognition (of a person's or a group's identity/culture) inflicts real harm, grounding claims for recognition of minority cultures within a shared political community.

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Marxist view of politics** with **Politics as an effect of class division, used by the dominant class to hold down the dependent class until class society is abolished.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 10

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **Politics as an effect of class division, used by the dominant class to hold down the dependent class until class society is abolished.**

A. Charles Taylor - significance B. Marxist view of politics C. Political situation D. Aristotle

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Politics as an effect of class division, used by the dominant class to hold down the dependent class until class society is abolished.** with **Marxist view of politics.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 11

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Communitarianism**?

A. Contemporary communitarians criticize the atomistic individual and stress embedded identity, virtue, shared understanding and common good. B. the self is unintelligible outside the narrative of a particular community and moral tradition; virtues are acquired only through participation in social "practices" (activities with internal standards of excellence - e.g. medicine, craft, scholarship) sustained by inherited traditions. C. A view stressing that persons are socially constituted, owe duties to the community, and should seek their good through the good of the community. D. grounds communitarian/multicultural claims in the human need for recognition - a moral, not merely sociological, case for community.

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Communitarianism** with **A view stressing that persons are socially constituted, owe duties to the community, and should seek their good through the good of the community.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 12

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **A view stressing that persons are socially constituted, owe duties to the community, and should seek their good through the good of the community.**

A. Michael Sandel - critique of the unencumbered self B. Authoritative allocation of values C. David Easton D. Communitarianism

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **A view stressing that persons are socially constituted, owe duties to the community, and should seek their good through the good of the community.** with **Communitarianism.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 13

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Aristotle**?

A. Politics begins with the polis, and communitarian strands later revive his idea that political association is tied to good life. B. A plurality of individuals and groups with reconcilable interests. C. a practice has "internal goods" (excellence achieved through the activity itself) understandable and judgeable only from within its own tradition of standards. D. targets Rawls's "original position," where parties choose principles of justice behind a "veil of ignorance," stripped of knowledge of their own particular ends and identity - Sandel calls this the "unencumbered self."

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Aristotle** with **Politics begins with the polis, and communitarian strands later revive his idea that political association is tied to good life..** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 14

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **Politics begins with the polis, and communitarian strands later revive his idea that political association is tied to good life.**

A. Michael Sandel - mechanism B. Aristotle C. Liberal view of politics D. Liberal-pluralist stream

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Politics begins with the polis, and communitarian strands later revive his idea that political association is tied to good life.** with **Aristotle**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 15

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **David Easton**?

A. Reconciliation and authoritative settlement of disputes. B. morality cannot be reconstructed from an abstract, tradition-free standpoint, as much liberal theory attempts; moral reasoning is always reasoning within an inherited tradition. C. Politics is the authoritative allocation of values for society. D. real persons are partly constituted by their ends and attachments (family, community, tradition); a self that could stand wholly apart from all its ends to choose principles of justice is not a coherent picture of a person.

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **David Easton** with **Politics is the authoritative allocation of values for society..** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 16

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **Politics is the authoritative allocation of values for society.**

A. Michael Sandel - significance B. Marxist view of politics C. Marx and Engels D. David Easton

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Politics is the authoritative allocation of values for society.** with **David Easton**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 17

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Liberal-pluralist stream**?

A. Locke-linked liberalism treats society as composed of multiple organized groups seeking accommodation through the state. B. A balanced outcome accommodating contending interests. C. the self is "dialogical," not monological - identity is formed through language and relationships with "significant others," and a person's self-understanding depends partly on being adequately recognised by others. D. if the self is constitutively social, justice cannot be derived from a purely neutral, ends-independent standpoint; political community itself has a claim prior to individual choice.

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Liberal-pluralist stream** with **Locke-linked liberalism treats society as composed of multiple organized groups seeking accommodation through the state..** The other options are

valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 18

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **Locke-linked liberalism treats society as composed of multiple organized groups seeking accommodation through the state.**

A. Politics B. Liberal-pluralist stream C. Communitarianism D. MacIntyre, Taylor, Sandel

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Locke-linked liberalism treats society as composed of multiple organized groups seeking accommodation through the state.** with **Liberal-pluralist stream.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 19

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Marx and Engels**?

A. Order, justice and welfare within society. B. withholding or distorting recognition (of a person's or a group's identity/culture) inflicts real harm, grounding claims for recognition of minority cultures within a shared political community. C. Politics and the state arise from class division and serve dominant-class interests until class conflict ends in a classless order. D. A public process involving conflict, its resolution, and authoritative value-allocation in society.

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Marx and Engels** with **Politics and the state arise from class division and serve dominant-class interests until class conflict ends in a classless order..** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 20

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **Politics and the state arise from class division and serve dominant-class interests until class conflict ends in a classless order.**

A. Political situation B. Aristotle C. Image of society D. Marx and Engels

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Politics and the state arise from class division and serve dominant-class interests until class conflict ends in a classless order.** with **Marx and Engels.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 21

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **MacIntyre, Taylor, Sandel**?

A. Contemporary communitarians criticize the atomistic individual and stress embedded identity, virtue, shared understanding and common good. B. the self is unintelligible outside the narrative of a particular community and moral tradition; virtues are acquired only through participation in social "practices" (activities with internal standards of excellence - e.g. medicine, craft, scholarship) sustained by inherited traditions. C. grounds communitarian/multicultural claims in the human need for recognition - a moral, not merely sociological, case for community. D. A situation of public conflict among major groups that calls for a universal/public solution, not a private settlement.

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **MacIntyre, Taylor, Sandel** with **Contemporary communitarians criticize the atomistic individual and stress embedded identity, virtue, shared understanding and common good..** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 22

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **Contemporary communitarians criticize the atomistic individual and stress embedded identity, virtue, shared understanding**

and common good.

A. Authoritative allocation of values B. MacIntyre, Taylor, Sandel C. David Easton D. Nature of politics

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Contemporary communitarians criticize the atomistic individual and stress embedded identity, virtue, shared understanding and common good.** with **MacIntyre, Taylor, Sandel**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 23

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Image of society**?

A. a practice has "internal goods" (excellence achieved through the activity itself) understandable and judgeable only from within its own tradition of standards. B. targets Rawls's "original position," where parties choose principles of justice behind a "veil of ignorance," stripped of knowledge of their own particular ends and identity - Sandel calls this the "unencumbered self." C. A plurality of individuals and groups with reconcilable interests. D. Easton's idea that politics distributes valued things through decisions treated as binding because they carry authority, not mere brute force.

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Image of society** with **A plurality of individuals and groups with reconcilable interests..** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 24

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **A plurality of individuals and groups with reconcilable interests.**

A. Liberal view of politics B. Liberal-pluralist stream C. Common good D. Image of society

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **A plurality of individuals and groups with reconcilable interests.** with **Image of society**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 25

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Nature of politics**?

A. Reconciliation and authoritative settlement of disputes. B. morality cannot be reconstructed from an abstract, tradition-free standpoint, as much liberal theory attempts; moral reasoning is always reasoning within an inherited tradition. C. real persons are partly constituted by their ends and attachments (family, community, tradition); a self that could stand wholly apart from all its ends to choose principles of justice is not a coherent picture of a person. D. Politics as group-and-state activity aimed at reconciling competing interests and promoting a common good compatible with them.

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Nature of politics** with **Reconciliation and authoritative settlement of disputes..** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 26

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **Reconciliation and authoritative settlement of disputes.**

A. Marxist view of politics B. Nature of politics C. Marx and Engels D. End-point

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Reconciliation and authoritative settlement of disputes.** with **Nature of politics**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 27

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Common good**?

A. the self is "dialogical," not monological - identity is formed through language and relationships with "significant others," and a person's self-understanding depends partly on being adequately recognised by others. B. if the self is constitutively social, justice cannot be derived from a purely neutral, ends-independent standpoint; political community itself has a claim prior to individual choice. C. A balanced outcome accommodating contending interests. D. Politics as an effect of class division, used by the dominant class to hold down the dependent class until class society is abolished.

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Common good** with **A balanced outcome accommodating contending interests**.. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 28

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **A balanced outcome accommodating contending interests**.

A. Communitarianism B. MacIntyre, Taylor, Sandel C. Alasdair MacIntyre - tradition and practices D. Common good

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **A balanced outcome accommodating contending interests**. with **Common good**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 29

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **End-point**?

A. Order, justice and welfare within society. B. withholding or distorting recognition (of a person's or a group's identity/culture) inflicts real harm, grounding claims for recognition of minority cultures within a shared political community. C. A public process involving conflict, its resolution, and authoritative value-allocation in society. D. A view stressing that persons are socially constituted, owe duties to the community, and should seek their good through the good of the community.

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **End-point** with **Order, justice and welfare within society**.. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 30

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **Order, justice and welfare within society**.

A. Aristotle B. End-point C. Image of society D. Alasdair MacIntyre - mechanism

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Order, justice and welfare within society**. with **End-point**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 31

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Alasdair MacIntyre - tradition and practices**?

A. grounds communitarian/multicultural claims in the human need for recognition - a moral, not merely sociological, case for community. B. A situation of public conflict among major groups that calls for a universal/public solution, not a private settlement. C. the self is unintelligible outside the narrative of a particular community and moral tradition; virtues are acquired only through participation in social "practices" (activities with internal standards of excellence - e.g. medicine, craft, scholarship) sustained by inherited traditions. D. Politics begins with the polis, and communitarian strands later revive his idea that political association is tied to good life.

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Alasdair MacIntyre - tradition and practices** with **the self is unintelligible outside the narrative of a particular community and moral tradition; virtues are acquired only through participation in social "practices" (activities with internal standards of excellence - e.g. medicine, craft, scholarship) sustained by inherited traditions..** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 32

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **the self is unintelligible outside the narrative of a particular community and moral tradition; virtues are acquired only through participation in social "practices" (activities with internal standards of excellence - e.g. medicine, craft, scholarship) sustained by inherited traditions.**

A. David Easton B. Nature of politics C. Alasdair MacIntyre - significance D. Alasdair MacIntyre - tradition and practices

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **the self is unintelligible outside the narrative of a particular community and moral tradition; virtues are acquired only through participation in social "practices" (activities with internal standards of excellence - e.g. medicine, craft, scholarship) sustained by inherited traditions.** with **Alasdair MacIntyre - tradition and practices.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 33

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Alasdair MacIntyre - mechanism**?

A. a practice has "internal goods" (excellence achieved through the activity itself) understandable and judgeable only from within its own tradition of standards. B. targets Rawls's "original position," where parties choose principles of justice behind a "veil of ignorance," stripped of knowledge of their own particular ends and identity - Sandel calls this the "unencumbered self." C. Easton's idea that politics distributes valued things through decisions treated as binding because they carry authority, not mere brute force. D. Politics is the authoritative allocation of values for society.

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Alasdair MacIntyre - mechanism** with **a practice has "internal goods" (excellence achieved through the activity itself) understandable and judgeable only from within its own tradition of standards..** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 34

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **a practice has "internal goods" (excellence achieved through the activity itself) understandable and judgeable only from within its own tradition of standards.**

A. Liberal-pluralist stream B. Alasdair MacIntyre - mechanism C. Common good D. Charles Taylor - dialogical self and recognition

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **a practice has "internal goods" (excellence achieved through the activity itself) understandable and judgeable only from within its own tradition of standards.** with **Alasdair MacIntyre - mechanism.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 35

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Alasdair MacIntyre - significance**?

A. real persons are partly constituted by their ends and attachments (family, community, tradition); a self that could stand wholly apart from all its ends to choose principles of justice is not a coherent picture of a person. B. Politics as group-and-state activity aimed at reconciling competing interests and promoting a common good compatible with

them. C. morality cannot be reconstructed from an abstract, tradition-free standpoint, as much liberal theory attempts; moral reasoning is always reasoning within an inherited tradition. D. Locke-linked liberalism treats society as composed of multiple organized groups seeking accommodation through the state.

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Alasdair MacIntyre - significance** with **morality cannot be reconstructed from an abstract, tradition-free standpoint, as much liberal theory attempts; moral reasoning is always reasoning within an inherited tradition..** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 36

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **morality cannot be reconstructed from an abstract, tradition-free standpoint, as much liberal theory attempts; moral reasoning is always reasoning within an inherited tradition.**

A. Marx and Engels B. End-point C. Charles Taylor - mechanism D. Alasdair MacIntyre - significance

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **morality cannot be reconstructed from an abstract, tradition-free standpoint, as much liberal theory attempts; moral reasoning is always reasoning within an inherited tradition.** with **Alasdair MacIntyre - significance.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 37

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Charles Taylor - dialogical self and recognition?**

A. the self is "dialogical," not monological - identity is formed through language and relationships with "significant others," and a person's self-understanding depends partly on being adequately recognised by others. B. if the self is constitutively social, justice cannot be derived from a purely neutral, ends-independent standpoint; political community itself has a claim prior to individual choice. C. Politics as an effect of class division, used by the dominant class to hold down the dependent class until class society is abolished. D. Politics and the state arise from class division and serve dominant-class interests until class conflict ends in a classless order.

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Charles Taylor - dialogical self and recognition** with **the self is "dialogical," not monological - identity is formed through language and relationships with "significant others," and a person's self-understanding depends partly on being adequately recognised by others..** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 38

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **the self is "dialogical," not monological - identity is formed through language and relationships with "significant others," and a person's self-understanding depends partly on being adequately recognised by others.**

A. MacIntyre, Taylor, Sandel B. Charles Taylor - dialogical self and recognition C. Alasdair MacIntyre - tradition and practices D. Charles Taylor - significance

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **the self is "dialogical," not monological - identity is formed through language and relationships with "significant others," and a person's self-understanding depends partly on being adequately recognised by others.** with **Charles Taylor - dialogical self and recognition.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 39

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Charles Taylor - mechanism?**

A. A public process involving conflict, its resolution, and authoritative value-allocation in society. B. A view stressing that persons are socially constituted, owe duties to the community, and should seek their good through the good of the community. C. withholding or distorting recognition (of a person's or a group's identity/culture) inflicts real harm, grounding claims for recognition of minority cultures within a shared political community. D. Contemporary communitarians criticize the atomistic individual and stress embedded identity, virtue, shared understanding and common good.

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Charles Taylor - mechanism** with **withholding or distorting recognition (of a person's or a group's identity/culture) inflicts real harm, grounding claims for recognition of minority cultures within a shared political community..** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 40

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **withholding or distorting recognition (of a person's or a group's identity/culture) inflicts real harm, grounding claims for recognition of minority cultures within a shared political community.**

A. Image of society B. Alasdair MacIntyre - mechanism C. Michael Sandel - critique of the unencumbered self D. Charles Taylor - mechanism

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **withholding or distorting recognition (of a person's or a group's identity/culture) inflicts real harm, grounding claims for recognition of minority cultures within a shared political community.** with **Charles Taylor - mechanism.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 41

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Charles Taylor - significance**?

A. grounds communitarian/multicultural claims in the human need for recognition - a moral, not merely sociological, case for community. B. A situation of public conflict among major groups that calls for a universal/public solution, not a private settlement. C. Politics begins with the polis, and communitarian strands later revive his idea that political association is tied to good life. D. A plurality of individuals and groups with reconcilable interests.

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Charles Taylor - significance** with **grounds communitarian/multicultural claims in the human need for recognition - a moral, not merely sociological, case for community..** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 42

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **grounds communitarian/multicultural claims in the human need for recognition - a moral, not merely sociological, case for community.**

A. Nature of politics B. Charles Taylor - significance C. Alasdair MacIntyre - significance D. Michael Sandel - mechanism

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **grounds communitarian/multicultural claims in the human need for recognition - a moral, not merely sociological, case for community.** with **Charles Taylor - significance.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 43

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Michael Sandel - critique of the unencumbered self**?

A. Easton's idea that politics distributes valued things through decisions treated as binding because they carry authority, not mere brute force. B. Politics is the authoritative allocation of values for society. C. targets Rawls's "original position," where parties choose principles of justice behind a "veil of ignorance," stripped of knowledge of their own particular ends and identity - Sandel calls this the "unencumbered self." D. Reconciliation and authoritative settlement of disputes.

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Michael Sandel - critique of the unencumbered self** with **targets Rawls's "original position," where parties choose principles of justice behind a "veil of ignorance," stripped of knowledge of their own particular ends and identity - Sandel calls this the "unencumbered self."** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 44

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **targets Rawls's "original position," where parties choose principles of justice behind a "veil of ignorance," stripped of knowledge of their own particular ends and identity - Sandel calls this the "unencumbered self."**

A. Common good B. Charles Taylor - dialogical self and recognition C. Michael Sandel - significance D. Michael Sandel - critique of the unencumbered self

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **targets Rawls's "original position," where parties choose principles of justice behind a "veil of ignorance," stripped of knowledge of their own particular ends and identity - Sandel calls this the "unencumbered self."** with **Michael Sandel - critique of the unencumbered self.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 45

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Michael Sandel - mechanism**?

A. real persons are partly constituted by their ends and attachments (family, community, tradition); a self that could stand wholly apart from all its ends to choose principles of justice is not a coherent picture of a person. B. Politics as group-and-state activity aimed at reconciling competing interests and promoting a common good compatible with them. C. Locke-linked liberalism treats society as composed of multiple organized groups seeking accommodation through the state. D. A balanced outcome accommodating contending interests.

Answer: A

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Michael Sandel - mechanism** with **real persons are partly constituted by their ends and attachments (family, community, tradition); a self that could stand wholly apart from all its ends to choose principles of justice is not a coherent picture of a person..** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 46

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **real persons are partly constituted by their ends and attachments (family, community, tradition); a self that could stand wholly apart from all its ends to choose principles of justice is not a coherent picture of a person.**

A. End-point B. Michael Sandel - mechanism C. Charles Taylor - mechanism D. Politics

Answer: B

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **real persons are partly constituted by their ends and attachments (family, community, tradition); a self that could stand wholly apart from all its ends to choose principles of justice is not a coherent picture of a person.** with **Michael Sandel - mechanism.** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 47

Which option correctly states the source-grounded meaning or position associated with **Michael Sandel - significance**?

A. Politics as an effect of class division, used by the dominant class to hold down the dependent class until class society is abolished. B. Politics and the state arise from class division and serve dominant-class interests until class conflict ends in a classless order. C. if the self is constitutively social, justice cannot be derived from a purely neutral, ends-independent standpoint; political community itself has a claim prior to individual choice. D. Order, justice and welfare within society.

Answer: C

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **Michael Sandel - significance** with **if the self is constitutively social, justice cannot be derived from a purely neutral, ends-independent standpoint; political community itself has a claim prior to individual choice..** The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

MCQ 48

Which concept, thinker or distinction is correctly associated with this source-grounded statement: **if the self is constitutively social, justice cannot be derived from a purely neutral, ends-independent standpoint; political community itself has a claim prior to individual choice.**

A. Alasdair MacIntyre - tradition and practices B. Charles Taylor - significance C. Political situation D. Michael Sandel - significance

Answer: D

Explanation: The canonical Basic owner pairs **if the self is constitutively social, justice cannot be derived from a purely neutral, ends-independent standpoint; political community itself has a claim prior to individual choice.** with **Michael Sandel - significance**. The other options are valid source terms or statements, but belong to different pairings.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQ STATUS

No directly owned verified UPSC PYQ is assigned to this Political Theory topic. Political Theory is a conceptual-support repository, and the source mapping expressly prohibits proxy, alias or synthetic PYQ routing. The questions below are therefore labelled as original practice, not PYQs.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Define a political situation and explain why authority, rather than brute force, is central to Easton's account of politics. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Introduction: A political situation arises when conflict over a public issue affects significant groups and requires a solution binding on society rather than a private settlement.

Core analysis: David Easton's formulation of politics as the authoritative allocation of values identifies both the object and the mode of political decision. Scarce or valued goods, burdens and opportunities are distributed through public policy. The resulting decisions are political because they are treated as binding by the community and are backed by recognised institutions. Authority may draw on legitimacy, habit, consent and the possibility of sanctions, whereas brute force secures only immediate submission. Gauba therefore distinguishes political settlement from war: war indicates the breakdown of an authoritative common solution rather than its successful operation.

Critical evaluation: Authority is not identical with moral rightness, and coercion can remain present within authoritative rule. The analytical point is that durable political order claims a publicly binding right to decide; violence alone cannot supply that claim.

Conclusion: Politics begins where public conflict requires a binding settlement, but it remains political only when decisions claim authority rather than reducing collective order to naked violence.

Why this earns marks: It defines the issue, states the controlling distinction, adds one limitation and closes with a direct verdict suited to a 10-mark answer.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks

Question: Distinguish the liberal, Marxist and communitarian views of politics. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Introduction: Liberal, Marxist and communitarian theories define politics differently because each begins from a different image of society.

Core analysis: The liberal view sees individuals and organised groups with diverse but reconcilable interests. Politics uses legitimate rules, bargaining and authoritative decisions to produce order, justice and welfare; its organising ideal is liberty. Marxism begins from antagonistic classes structured by ownership and exploitation. Political compromise inside class society often manages or suppresses conflict while preserving dominant-class power; its organising ideal is equality and its horizon is a classless society. Communitarianism begins from socially constituted persons linked by belonging, duties and shared understandings. Politics should identify and pursue a common good through cooperation; its organising ideal is fraternity.

Critical evaluation: These are ideal types rather than exhaustive descriptions of every society. Gauba's conditional conclusion is crucial: reconciliation is less plausible under extreme domination, while communitarian cooperation is less plausible amid deep inequality and disagreement.

Conclusion: The three views are rival social ontologies, not merely rival policies: liberalism begins from plural interests, Marxism from antagonistic classes, and communitarianism from socially embedded persons pursuing a shared good.

Why this earns marks: It defines the issue, states the controlling distinction, adds one limitation and closes with a direct verdict suited to a 10-mark answer.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 15 marks

Question: Examine the communitarian critique of the atomistic liberal self with reference to MacIntyre, Taylor and Sandel. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Introduction: Communitarianism challenges the liberal picture of a self whose identity and purposes can be understood independently of social membership.

Core analysis: MacIntyre argues that persons acquire virtues through practices, narratives and inherited traditions. The standards internal to medicine, craft or scholarship cannot be generated by an isolated chooser. Taylor describes identity as dialogical: language and relations with significant others make self-understanding possible, while misrecognition can damage persons and groups. Sandel targets Rawls's supposedly unencumbered chooser. Actual persons are partly constituted by attachments and ends, so justice cannot simply begin from a self pictured as prior to them. The three mechanisms must remain distinct: tradition and practices, recognition and dialogue, and the critique of the unencumbered self.

Critical evaluation: The liberal reply is that Rawls's original position is a device for choosing fair principles, not a metaphysical description of actual persons. Liberal rights also protect individuals who criticise oppressive traditions. Communitarianism therefore establishes social embeddedness, but not the moral authority of every existing community.

Conclusion: The communitarian critique successfully exposes the social conditions of agency, but it does not eliminate liberal rights; it requires a more socially situated liberalism capable of protecting both belonging and critical independence.

Why this earns marks: It combines definition, named doctrinal evidence, comparison and a counter-position before giving a qualified 15-mark verdict.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks

Question: Is liberal neutrality possible? Discuss the communitarian objection and the liberal reply. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Introduction: Liberal neutrality means that political institutions should not impose one comprehensive conception of the good on citizens who reasonably disagree.

Core analysis: Communitarians object that neutrality is neither possible nor innocent. A liberal state already values autonomy, rights and the choosing individual, so it promotes a particular moral image while claiming to stand above competing goods. It may also weaken the practices and loyalties on which citizenship depends. The Rawlsian reply distinguishes political from metaphysical neutrality. Fair procedures and equal liberties do not assert that persons lack constitutive attachments; they specify terms of cooperation acceptable across rival doctrines. Public institutions may support the capacities needed for citizenship without declaring one final way of life.

Critical evaluation: The reply limits rather than abolishes the objection. Selection of rights, public reasons and institutional priorities always reflects judgments. Neutrality is therefore plausible as restraint against comprehensive coercion, but implausible as complete value-freedom. Its legitimacy depends on transparent justification and space for communal as well as individual forms of life.

Conclusion: Liberal neutrality is defensible as a limited political rule of fair cooperation, not as a claim that the state or the self can be wholly detached from every conception of the good.

Why this earns marks: It combines definition, named doctrinal evidence, comparison and a counter-position before giving a qualified 15-mark verdict.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 20 marks

Question: Is politics best understood as reconciliation, class domination or pursuit of the common good? Critically discuss. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Introduction: Politics is a public process of conflict, authoritative decision and collective order, but liberal, Marxist and communitarian theories disagree about its dominant social logic.

Core analysis: Liberal pluralism interprets society as multiple groups whose interests can be accommodated through rules, negotiation and legitimate state action. Politics is consequently reconciliation directed toward order, justice and welfare. Marxism argues that this image understates structural power: where ownership divides society into antagonistic classes, compromise may suppress conflict while reproducing domination. Communitarianism rejects both the isolated interest-bearer and the permanently divided class model. Because persons are socially constituted, politics can express cooperation and a common good that comprehends members' flourishing. Gauba aligns the three views with liberty, equality and fraternity.

Further development: The theories can also be treated as condition-sensitive diagnoses. Liberal reconciliation is most credible where disparities are moderate, institutions are legitimate and parties can bargain without dependence. Marxist domination becomes more illuminating where ownership structures bargaining power before public negotiation begins. Communitarian cooperation requires shared practices and sufficient social trust, but cannot be assumed in a fragmented or deeply unequal society. The best answer therefore moves from social ontology to evidence: identify who the actors are, how power is distributed, whether decisions command authority and whether the alleged common good is open to contestation. Politics may contain all three logics at once, though one can dominate in a given context.

Critical evaluation: Each account captures a real dimension but becomes misleading when universalised. Liberalism is thin where bargaining positions are radically unequal; Marxism can reduce plural identities and institutional autonomy to class; communitarianism can romanticise solidarity where power and opinion remain deeply divided.

Conclusion: Politics cannot be reduced to one permanent essence: its dominant form depends on the depth of conflict, the distribution of power and the extent to which citizens can sustain a genuinely shared good.

Why this earns marks: It develops multiple dimensions and named evidence units, tests the strongest objection and reply, and reaches a balanced 20-mark judgment.

Original Mains Practice 6 - 20 marks

Question: Evaluate communitarianism as an alternative to liberalism, with reference to embedded selfhood, the common good and its limits. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Introduction: Communitarianism is an alternative to atomistic liberalism because it treats social membership as constitutive of identity and political obligation rather than as a merely voluntary association among prior individuals.

Core analysis: MacIntyre locates moral agency in practices and traditions; Taylor explains the dialogical formation of identity and the need for recognition; Sandel argues that the Rawlsian unencumbered self neglects constitutive attachments. These claims support a common-good politics in which duties, cooperation and fraternity matter alongside rights. Rousseau's general will and T.H. Green's social account of self-realisation may be used cautiously as precursors, not as contemporary communitarians. The approach illuminates local association, civic responsibility and the social foundations of individual flourishing.

Further development: The Indian application should remain cautious. Constitutional life combines individual rights with directive duties and community-oriented purposes, illustrating an institutional attempt to hold liberty and fraternity together without treating either as absolute. The 27 July 2026 Panchayati Raj initiatives offer a current conceptual anchor: the Atmanirbhar Panchayat Programme, SAMARTH Panchayat Portal and Model Own Source Revenue Rules seek to strengthen local collective capacity and revenue governance. They illustrate how common purposes may be organised through local institutions, but they do not prove that a village has one homogeneous good. Inclusion, fiscal transparency, dissent and rights remain tests of whether local solidarity is genuinely common rather than majoritarian.

Critical evaluation: Its limits are equally serious. Traditions may be hierarchical, communities may silence internal minorities, recognition claims may fragment citizenship, and a supposed common good may conceal dominant interests. Liberals answer that fair rights and procedures permit embedded persons to cooperate while retaining exit, dissent and revision. Communitarianism therefore corrects liberal social ontology, but cannot replace constitutional protection of the individual.

Conclusion: Communitarianism corrects liberal atomism by restoring belonging, recognition and common purpose, but it remains defensible only when community is internally contestable and bounded by equal rights.

Why this earns marks: It develops multiple dimensions and named evidence units, tests the strongest objection and reply, and reaches a balanced 20-mark judgment.